

## AI ETHICS LEARNING TOOLKIT

# Who Benefits From AI?

Exploring the AI Divide and AI Info Privilege

**“We have a computing divide at the heart of the A.I. revolution...It’s not merely a hardware problem. It’s the sovereignty of our digital future.”**

**– Lacina Koné, the director general of Smart Africa**

An extension of the digital divide, the AI divide refers to the growing gap between individuals, communities, and companies who have access to cutting-edge Artificial Intelligence tools and those who do not. Roughly one-third of the global population (2.6 billion people) does not have regular access to the internet (which would include AI). Beyond physical access to technology – like hardware, software, or premium AI subscriptions – this divide also includes disparities in access to education and skills training that are critical for using AI effectively. AI’s rapid integration into the workplace disproportionately affects people in low-wage or routine jobs, who are more likely to face displacement from the jobs of the future. At the industry level, development and control of

advanced AI is concentrated in the hands of multi-billion dollar, “Big Tech” corporations – such as Meta, OpenAI, Amazon, X, Google, and Microsoft. Although smaller start-ups are entering the AI space, they must overcome huge barriers, including the high cost of training LLMs and limited access to high-quality datasets. In learning about AI, students should reflect on their own AI privileges, as well as global AI divides, and consider what efforts could be effective in bridging the AI divide.

## Learning Activities



### **Conversation Starters** A Few Questions to Get the Discussion Going

- Who is harmed, and who benefits, from access to AI technology?
- Are there AI tools that you pay for premium subscriptions to (ex. Premium ChatGPT, Grammarly)? If so, how does that benefit you? If not, what disadvantages might you face?
- What are some types of jobs you could see being replaced by AI?
- What are some ways we can ensure equitable access to AI and AI training?



### **Active Learning with AI** Fun Ways to Explore AI's Strengths and Limitations

- Freemium AI vs. Premium AI. Students can investigate the

difference between access to a freemium version of ChatGPT vs. Duke's premium subscription.

- Educational / Information Privilege backpack. Ask students to work alone to brainstorm the educational/info privileges they've observed in K-12 and college settings. Ask them to include at least a couple "AI" privileges. ([Examples and blank backpack](#) activity).
- Role play. Assign roles to groups of students (community college vs. R1 University; private K-12 school vs. underfunded public school; small business vs. large corporation). Students research and brainstorm some of the advantages/disadvantages their assigned organization faces in the age of AI.



## Disciplinary Extensions

Ideas for Exploring AI's Impact in Specific Fields

- **Public Policy/Education:** Students could research and present on a proposed intervention or policy for improving the AI divide in a particular context (K-12, higher ed).
- **Economics:** Students can "follow the money" and research top tech companies, funders, partnerships, and data sources. Compare/contrast availability of \$ and resources between big tech companies and smaller start-ups.
- **Computer Science:** Students could discuss the factors that benefit students studying CS at a university like Duke, in contrast to a community college, or less-resourced institution?

## Resources

- Satariano, A., Mozur, P., Russell, K., & Kim, J. (2025, June 23). [The A.I. Race Is Splitting the World Into Haves and Have-Nots](#). *The New York Times*. [News article] The New York Times logo, featuring the words "The New York Times" in a serif font, with a small icon of the newspaper's masthead to the right.

- Trucano, M. (2023). [AI and the next digital divide in education](#). *Brookings*. [Blog post] 
- Gay, R. (2012, May 16). [Peculiar benefits](#). *The Rumpus*. [Blog post] 
- Booth, char. (2014, December 1). [On Information Privilege](#). *Info-Mational*. [Blog post] 

## Scholarly

- Kak, A., West, S., & Whittaker, M. (2023). [Make no mistake—AI is owned by Big Tech](#). *MIT Technology Review*. [Article]  
- Gonzales, S. (2024, August 6). [AI literacy and the new Digital Divide—A Global Call for Action](#). *UNESCO*. [Report] 

## Recommendations

- Related topics → Is AI biased?
- [AI Pedagogy Project \(Harvard\) Assignments](#) → Filter by theme (e.g. bias) and/or subject (e.g. ethics & philosophy)



1. Satariano, A., Mozur, P., Russell, K., & Kim, J. (2025, June 23). The A.I. Race Is Splitting the World Into Haves and Have-Nots. *The New York Times*.
2. International Telecommunication Union (ITU). (2023, September 12). [Population of global offline continues steady decline to 2.6 billion people in 2023](#) [UN]. ITU.Int.

## PHYSICAL LOCATION

The Erwin Square Mill Building  
2024 West Main Street  
Durham, NC 27705

## MAILING ADDRESS

Box 90700  
Durham, NC 27708

## CONTACT US

Phone: (919) 660-5806  
Email:  
learninginnovation@duke.edu

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